

Module 10: Leadership, Community, and Legacy

MISSION REBUILD™ | 12-Week Transition Course for Military Veterans

Module 10 of 12

Module Overview

Here's the thing nobody tells you when you get out: you were built to lead. You've led people under conditions most civilians will never experience — sleep-deprived, under pressure, with lives on the line. You've made high-stakes decisions with incomplete information. You've trained people, held the line, and brought people home.

And now you're in a cubicle being managed by a 28-year-old who's never been uncomfortable a day in their life.

That frustration you're feeling? It's not arrogance. It's a leadership capacity looking for a mission.

The problem isn't your ability. The problem is the translation. Military leadership runs on rank, structure, and authority. Civilian leadership runs on influence, trust, and relationships. Those are different languages — and if you don't learn the civilian dialect, all that capacity sits dormant while people who are less capable but better politically navigate around you.

This module is about refusing to let that happen.

We're going to talk about what it actually means to lead without rank. We're going to talk about where veterans are desperately needed in civic life — city councils, school boards, nonprofits, community organizations — and how to show up there in a way that makes an actual difference instead of just making noise. We're going to talk about mentorship, because at some point you became the person who has something to give, and there are younger veterans who are exactly where you were three years ago who need someone to reach back a hand.

We're going to talk about your voice — how to speak publicly, how to tell your story, how to claim the authority you've already earned. And we're going to talk about legacy: not the grandiose kind, not monuments and statues, but the real kind. The kind built through consistent action, through showing up, through being the person your community can count on.

Service doesn't end when you take off the uniform. For most veterans, it just changes form.

This module is about finding that form.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, you will be able to:

1. **Distinguish between authority-based and influence-based leadership**, and develop a personal strategy for building influence in civilian and professional environments without relying on rank or positional power.
 2. **Identify specific civic engagement opportunities** in your community where your veteran skills, perspective, and leadership capacity create genuine value — and take concrete first steps toward involvement.
 3. **Build a functioning mentorship practice** — both as a mentor to those coming behind you and as a mentee seeking guidance from those further ahead — with clear structures, boundaries, and goals.
 4. **Develop your public speaking confidence and personal story framework**, enabling you to represent yourself powerfully in professional settings, veteran panels, speaking engagements, and community forums.
-

Lesson 1: Leadership Without a Rank

The Structure You Lost — And What Replaces It

When you were in, leadership was built into the architecture. You wore your rank. People knew your authority before you opened your mouth. Expectations were clear. The chain of command existed to organize effort, resolve conflict, and establish accountability. You didn't have to earn the right to lead every day — the institution backed you up.

Civilian life stripped that infrastructure away.

Now you walk into rooms and nobody knows what you've done, what you've led, or what you're capable of. Your credibility isn't displayed on your collar — it has to be demonstrated over time, through behavior, through results, through relationships. For veterans who are used to walking into a room and having the situation read them accurately, this is disorienting at best and infuriating at worst.

Let's name the adjustment clearly: **you have gone from authority-based leadership to influence-based leadership**. Both are legitimate. Both require real skill. But they operate on completely

different foundations.

Authority-based leadership works because of position. Your subordinates follow you because the institution says they have to, because there are consequences for not complying, and because the structure creates clarity about who decides what. This isn't cynical — it's functional. It works in high-stakes, time-compressed environments where you can't stop to build consensus before every decision.

Influence-based leadership works because of relationship, credibility, and perceived value. People follow you because they trust you, because they've seen you deliver, because your judgment has proven sound, because they believe you're invested in outcomes that include them. This is slower to build. It doesn't come with automatic authority. But it's more durable, more portable, and — done well — more powerful than rank ever was.

Here's what most veterans miss: everything you learned about leadership in the military still applies. The principles are the same. Lead by example. Communicate clearly. Hold people accountable. Take care of your people. Make decisions. Own outcomes. The *skills* are absolutely transferable.

What doesn't transfer automatically is the *context* — the shared language, the institutional backing, the assumed authority. You have to rebuild that context in every new environment you enter. And that means being patient in a way that combat deployment didn't require.

How Veterans Adapt: A Framework

The veterans who lead most effectively in civilian life do a few things consistently:

1. They lead through service, not command.

Rank-based leaders can afford to issue orders and expect execution. Influence-based leaders get results by removing obstacles for their teams, by investing in people's development, by being the person who makes everyone else's job easier. In civilian environments, the fastest way to build influence is to be genuinely useful. Not performatively busy — useful. If you're a manager, this means your team solves problems faster because you're in the room. If you're a new employee, this means you take on hard things without being asked. If you're an entrepreneur, this means your clients feel taken care of at a level that surprises them.

2. They listen before they lead.

This one is hard. In high-stakes military environments, hesitation can cost lives. You develop a bias for action because that bias keeps people alive. But in most civilian environments, the failure mode isn't too little action — it's too little understanding. Veterans who blow into a new environment, assess in 72 hours, and start issuing recommendations often get dismissed or ignored, not because they're wrong, but

because they haven't built the relational capital that makes people receptive to their observations. Listen first. Understand the political landscape, the history, the informal power structures. Then lead.

3. They build relationships before they need them.

Networking feels manipulative to a lot of veterans. It's not something the military culture celebrated — you did your job, and if you were good, that was enough. But in civilian life, your network is your infrastructure. The difference between getting the opportunity and not getting the opportunity is often simply whether someone in the room knows you and trusts you. Build relationships before you need them. Be generous with your time, your connections, your expertise. Invest in people without keeping score. That's not networking as a transaction — that's community as a strategy.

4. They own their discomfort.

The veterans who get stuck are the ones who let frustration calcify into contempt. They look at their civilian environment — the bureaucracy, the consensus-seeking, the slower pace, the different priorities — and they write it off as weakness. That's a trap. The civilian environment isn't broken — it's different. And if you can't adapt your leadership to fit the environment, you're not actually a great leader yet. You're just someone who was good at one specific context. Real leadership is contextual flexibility. Own the discomfort of learning a new context. It's temporary. The capacity you're building is permanent.

The Leadership Muscle That Never Atrophied

Here's what's worth remembering: most of your civilian peers have never been in a real high-stakes environment. They've never had to maintain composure under genuine pressure, make hard calls with lives on the line, or keep a team functional when everything is going sideways.

You have. That experience doesn't go away. It shows up as calm in crisis. It shows up as decisiveness when everyone else is paralyzed. It shows up as endurance when the project runs long and the team is burning out.

That is an enormous asset. The key is learning to deploy it in ways the civilian environment can receive — without making people feel judged, without making every challenge a combat metaphor, without leading from a place of impatience.

You were built to lead. Now you're learning to lead in a new language. Give yourself the grace period that requires, without giving yourself permission to stop pushing.

Lesson 2: Civic Engagement and Community Impact

Where Veterans Are Needed — And Why They're Not Showing Up

Here's a gap nobody talks about enough: America's civic institutions are struggling, and veterans are exactly the kind of people those institutions need — and they're largely absent from them.

City councils. School boards. Planning commissions. Nonprofit boards. Veterans service organizations. Local emergency management committees. Fire department auxiliary boards. Hospital system community councils. Water district boards.

These are the mechanisms by which communities govern themselves, allocate resources, solve problems, and build institutions that last. And they are almost universally populated by people who have one thing in common: they showed up.

That's it. They showed up.

Most positions of civic leadership are not won through extreme qualification or political genius — they're won through presence, consistency, and the willingness to do work that most people would rather outsource to someone else. Veterans, who have spent entire careers showing up — early, ready, prepared — are naturally suited to this. And yet veterans are drastically underrepresented in civic leadership at the local level.

Why? A few reasons:

The cultural gap is real. Civic meetings are long. They involve a lot of talking. The decision-making can feel circular and political in a way that military planning never was. Veterans who expect efficiency and clarity often get frustrated and disengage before they've had a chance to build influence.

The civilian timeline is different. Nobody gets elected to city council six months after getting out. The path to meaningful civic influence takes time — typically two to five years of consistent involvement before you hold a formal leadership position. That's a hard sell for someone used to accelerated responsibility.

Nobody recruited them. In the military, someone identified your potential and put you in positions to develop. In civic life, nobody is knocking on your door asking you to run for the school board. The initiative has to be yours.

But here's the case for overcoming all of that: **local government is where your daily life actually happens.**

Federal politics is a circus with a 24-hour news cycle. State politics is important but remote. Local government — your city council, your county commission, your school board — determines what your roads look like, whether your schools are functional, how your police department operates, how development happens in your neighborhood, how your tax dollars get spent. And these decisions are being made, right now, by whoever showed up.

You have the discipline, the planning capability, the leadership experience, and the ethics to make these institutions dramatically better. The question is whether you'll decide that civic involvement is worth your time.

Entry Points: Where to Start

City and County Government

Most city councils and county commissions have advisory boards and commissions that feed into their decision-making. These include planning and zoning commissions, parks and recreation boards, public safety advisory committees, budget oversight committees, and more. These positions are often appointed rather than elected, which means you can get involved without running a political campaign. Start here. Attend a few meetings. Introduce yourself to staff. Ask what committees have openings. Within six to twelve months of consistent attendance and good-faith participation, you can be in a room where real decisions are being influenced.

Nonprofit Boards

Nonprofits are mission-driven organizations that almost always need more leadership capacity than they have. Veterans service organizations specifically need veterans who understand both the mission and the business of running an effective organization. But don't limit yourself to veteran-specific nonprofits. Homeless shelters, food banks, youth development organizations, workforce training programs — these organizations serve your community and need board members with operational experience. Serving on a nonprofit board builds your civic network, develops your governance skills, and puts you in contact with civic leaders in other sectors.

School Boards

School boards govern one of the most consequential institutions in your community: the schools your kids attend, or the schools your neighbors' kids attend. School board members are elected in most jurisdictions, and they have real authority over curriculum, budget, personnel, and policy. School board elections are typically low-turnout, low-budget affairs where a candidate with strong community ties and a clear message can win without a massive political machine. Veterans have an enormous amount to offer school governance — operational discipline, strategic planning, accountability culture, and a genuine stake in outcomes.

Emergency Management and Public Safety

If your background is in combat arms, intelligence, logistics, or any operational specialty, your skills map directly onto emergency management. Many local jurisdictions have volunteer auxiliary programs, community emergency response teams (CERT), and advisory committees that welcome people with

operational planning experience. This is a natural first step that keeps you connected to mission-oriented work while building community relationships.

Political Campaigns and Partisan Politics

This is a personal decision, and it's not for everyone — the military's tradition of apolitical professionalism runs deep, and many veterans feel uncomfortable with overtly partisan work even after separating. But if you have strong views and a willingness to advocate for them, politics is a legitimate avenue. Campaigns need people who can organize, execute, and lead volunteers. If you believe in a candidate or a cause, getting involved in their campaign is a concrete way to develop political relationships and understand how civic change actually gets made.

The Veteran Advantage in Civic Spaces

When veterans engage in civic life with their full capability — not their military jargon, not their command presence, but their actual capacity for planning, accountability, and execution — they tend to stand out quickly.

You know how to read a budget. You know how to manage a complex project across multiple stakeholders. You know how to make decisions under uncertainty. You know how to hold people accountable without making it personal. You know how to communicate clearly when clarity matters.

These skills are rare in civic institutions. They are desperately needed. And they are yours, already paid for, available for deployment wherever you choose to point them.

The community you live in needs you to show up. Not as a veteran identity — not with your service as your calling card — but as a competent, committed civic actor who happens to have an extraordinary background.

Show up. Consistently. That's 80% of civic engagement.

Lesson 3: Mentorship — Being the Person You Needed

You're Further Along Than You Think

There's a veteran sitting somewhere right now — maybe three years out, maybe eighteen months out — who is exactly where you were when you first got out. They're disoriented. They don't know how to read the civilian landscape. They're carrying things they haven't processed. They're not sure whether they made the right call leaving. They're struggling to explain their experience in a resume or an interview. They're isolated in a way that surprises them because they've never been isolated before.

That person needs someone who has been there.

They don't need a counselor. They don't need a formal program. They don't need another resource list. They need someone who looks at them, sees exactly what's happening, and says: *I know this feeling. I've been here. Here's what actually helped.*

That person is you.

Mentorship in the veteran community is not optional leadership development — it's a moral responsibility. You made it through the transition far enough to be in this course. You have knowledge that would have been invaluable to you eighteen months ago. Refusing to share that knowledge because you're busy, or because you're not sure you're qualified, or because you think formal programs exist for that — that's a choice that costs someone else more than you realize.

This lesson is about building a mentorship practice that is useful, sustainable, and honest — not a performance of caring, but actual investment in someone else's growth.

What Effective Veteran Mentorship Actually Looks Like

Good mentorship is not giving advice constantly. It's not telling your war stories. It's not projecting your transition experience onto someone else's and assuming they're dealing with the same things. It's not making yourself feel good by being the wise elder.

Good mentorship looks like this:

Ask more than you tell. Your job as a mentor is to help someone think through their own situation more clearly — not to hand them your conclusions. The best questions you can ask are the ones that help them articulate what they actually want, what they're actually afraid of, and what's actually getting in the way. "What does success look like to you in twelve months?" is more useful than "Here's what I did."

Show up on schedule. If you commit to meeting once a month, meet once a month. Veterans who've been burned by unreliable institutions — civilian employers, VA systems, informal promises — are acutely sensitive to whether the people in their lives actually follow through. Being reliable is itself a form of mentorship. It models the behavior you want them to develop.

Be honest about your own stumbles. The version of your transition that you share with your mentee should not be the polished LinkedIn narrative. It should include the months where you didn't have a plan, the job you hated but needed the income, the times you almost quit. The sanitized success story is less useful than the honest one. Your failures and the lessons you drew from them are often more valuable than your wins.

Respect autonomy. Your mentee will make choices you wouldn't make. They will take paths you disagree with. Unless those paths are genuinely dangerous, your job is not to veto their decisions — it's to help them think through their choices and support them in executing whatever they decide. Mentorship that turns into control isn't mentorship.

Know your limits. If someone is dealing with serious mental health issues, trauma symptoms, substance use, or suicidal ideation, your job is not to be their therapist — it's to care enough to point them toward someone who can actually help. You can be a powerful positive presence in someone's life without being the only support they have. Help them build a full support system, not just a dependency on you.

How to Find and Work With Your Own Mentors

You are not done needing mentors. No matter how far along you are in this transition, there are people ahead of you in the specific areas where you're trying to grow — entrepreneurs who have already built what you're building, executives who navigated the C-suite as veterans, civic leaders who understand the political terrain, financial advisors who've worked specifically with veterans, people who have built the life you're trying to design.

Finding them requires initiative and some willingness to be vulnerable:

Be specific about what you need. "Can I pick your brain sometime?" is a low-probability request. "I'm six months out of the Army, building a construction business, and I'm struggling with the sales side — would you be willing to meet once a month to help me think through that specific challenge?" is a much higher-probability request. People are more willing to mentor when they know exactly what you need from them.

Invest before you ask. Before you ask someone to be your mentor, find ways to create value for them first. Share an article relevant to their work. Connect them with someone useful. Engage thoughtfully with their content. Come to a meeting they're speaking at and ask a good question. Being a mentee who is already useful is far more attractive than being a mentee who just needs things.

Respect their time. Come to every meeting prepared. Have a specific question or challenge ready. Do the work between sessions. If your mentor gives you something to do, do it and report back. Nothing ends a mentoring relationship faster than a mentee who doesn't do the work.

Multiple mentors for multiple domains. You probably shouldn't have one mentor for everything. Have someone who mentors you on career and business, someone who mentors you on leadership development, someone who mentors you on finances, maybe someone who mentors you on health. Different people have different depths of knowledge, and spreading your mentorship across multiple relationships means you're getting specialized input rather than one person's generalized opinion.

Peer Mentorship: The Network That Moves Together

Don't overlook the power of peer mentorship — relationships with veterans who are at a similar stage of transition, wrestling with similar challenges, building in similar directions.

Find your cohort. The people who got out around the same time you did, who are building civilian lives with the same intentionality you are. Check in with each other. Share resources, connections, job leads, hard-won lessons. This peer network is often more immediately useful than formal mentorship because the challenges are the same, the context is shared, and there's no power differential to navigate.

Build a peer group, not just a mentor list. Both matter.

Lesson 4: Public Speaking and Personal Authority

Your Story Is Your Credibility

Here is something most veterans don't fully understand: **your story is one of the most compelling things in any room you walk into.**

The civilian world is fascinated by military service. Most civilians have no frame of reference for what you've done, where you've been, and what you've seen. When you speak about your experience — honestly, specifically, without either glorifying or minimizing it — you capture attention in a way that is genuinely rare.

The problem is that most veterans either undersell or oversell.

Underselling looks like: "I was in the Army for eight years, did some deployments, drove trucks." The combat truck driver who ran 400 missions in Kandahar without losing a single vehicle is describing that as "I drove trucks" because the culture of service trained you not to glorify yourself. That humility is admirable. It is also, in a civilian context, self-defeating.

Overselling looks like: constant deployment references, combat metaphors for every business challenge, leading with service as a claim to moral superiority. Civilians who haven't been in service can't fully evaluate these claims, which means they often either over-romanticize them or feel subtly manipulated. Neither is useful.

The middle path is **specific, honest storytelling that connects your experience to the value you create in civilian contexts.**

Building Your Personal Story Framework

Think of your personal story in three movements:

Movement 1: The Mission

What did you do? Not what was your MOS or your unit designation — what did you actually *do*? What was the mission, what was at stake, what was your role, and what happened? Be specific enough to be real, general enough to be comprehensible to someone who wasn't there. One or two specific moments or missions can anchor this more effectively than a comprehensive career summary.

Movement 2: The Translation

What did that experience develop in you? Not the generic list — not "leadership, teamwork, discipline" — but the specific capacities that come from your specific experience. A logistician has developed a kind of systems-thinking under pressure that is extremely rare in civilian supply chain. An intelligence analyst has developed a precision of sourcing and inference that is rare in business intelligence. A combat leader has developed a composure in crisis that is worth a great deal in high-stakes business environments. Name your actual capacities.

Movement 3: The Application

How does what you built in service make you valuable, interesting, or capable in what you're doing now? How are you applying those capacities? Where are they showing up? This is the bridge between your past and your present — the part that makes your story relevant to the audience, not just interesting.

Practice this framework until you can deliver it in ninety seconds without it sounding like a prepared speech. Then expand it into a longer form — five minutes, ten minutes — for contexts that warrant more depth.

Public Speaking as a Leadership Tool

You may not think of yourself as a public speaker. The people who define themselves that way tend to be a specific personality type — charismatic, extroverted, comfortable in the spotlight. You may not be that person.

That's fine. Public speaking is not a personality trait — it's a skill. And it's one of the highest-leverage skills you can develop, because the ability to speak clearly and compellingly in front of a group amplifies every other capability you have.

Here's how to develop it without going the route of generic public speaking courses:

Start local and low-stakes. Speak at a veteran service organization meeting. Tell your story at a community event. Present a project update at work. Volunteer to speak at a local college's career day.

Every rep at low stakes builds the capacity for high stakes.

Join a structured practice environment. Toastmasters gets mocked as corny but it works. So do public speaking boot camps, local Rotary clubs that welcome speakers, and veteran-specific speaking programs. The point is consistent, feedback-rich practice.

Pursue panel opportunities. Before you're ready to give a keynote, you can serve on panels — at universities, at veteran conferences, at professional association events, at community organizations. Panels are lower-pressure than solo speaking because the conversation is shared, and they still build your comfort with public delivery and on-the-spot articulation.

Pursue TEDx if your story is ready. TEDx talks are not reserved for celebrities and academics. They're organized by local communities, and they actively seek speakers with compelling stories and genuine insights. A well-delivered TEDx talk — one that is honest, specific, and connects your experience to a universal human theme — can reach tens of thousands of people and establish your public credibility in a way that takes years to build through other means. If you have a story that the world needs to hear, TEDx is worth pursuing.

The speaking circuit. Veterans who develop strong storytelling and public speaking capability often find a market for professional speaking — at corporate events, at military conferences, at universities, at professional development programs. This can be a revenue stream, a platform, or simply a way of contributing. It starts with speaking for free, building your reputation and your story, and progressively moving toward paid opportunities as demand develops.

Authority in the Room

Even when you're not formally speaking, your presence and communication style project authority — or they don't. A few things that matter:

Stillness under pressure. When a meeting gets heated, when a client is frustrated, when a negotiation turns adversarial — how you hold your composure in that moment tells everyone in the room a great deal about your leadership capacity. You've been trained for far worse. Use that.

Economy of words. Veterans who've operated in environments where verbal precision was operationally critical tend to say what they mean in fewer words than civilian counterparts who have learned to fill silence with talk. That economy, in a civilian professional environment, projects confidence and intelligence. Don't unlearn it.

Owning the preparation. Walking into a room prepared — knowing the stakeholders, understanding the agenda, having done the analysis — is itself a form of authority. You can't fake preparation. And preparation, more than any personality trait, is the foundation of real confidence.

Lesson 5: Building a Legacy Beyond the Uniform

What Does Service After Service Look Like?

Legacy is a word that gets thrown around a lot, usually in ways that are either grandiose or vague. Everyone wants a legacy. Very few people are specific enough about what they mean to actually build one.

Let's be direct: **a legacy is not what people say about you when you're gone. A legacy is what continues after you stop actively pushing it.** It's the institutions you helped build. The people you developed who went on to develop others. The culture you created in an organization. The civic improvements you fought for that are still serving your community twenty years later. The children you raised. The example you set.

A legacy is almost never accidental. It's the long-term accumulation of intentional choices made consistently over time.

For veterans, the question of legacy carries particular weight because you've already lived a version of it. In service, your work was embedded in something larger than yourself. There was mission, there was unit, there was country. Whatever the politics of any particular war or deployment, the sense of purpose was clear and the community of people around you was real.

Civilian life doesn't hand you that structure. You have to build it. And what you build, how you build it, and who you build it with — that's your legacy.

The Vectors of Veteran Legacy

Legacy doesn't have to be a single grand project. It accumulates along multiple vectors simultaneously:

The People Vector

The most durable form of legacy is human. The mentees you develop who go on to lead. The children you raise with values. The employees you invest in who build their own careers on what you gave them. The fellow veterans you helped stabilize during hard transitions who then go on to help others. This is legacy at its most direct and most certain — because while institutions can fail and projects can end, the impact you have on people who then carry it forward is genuinely self-replicating.

Invest in people. Develop people. Give more than you take. Do this consistently for twenty years and you will have built something that cannot be undone.

The Institution Vector

Some veterans build organizations — nonprofits, businesses, civic institutions — that outlast them. The veterans who founded the DAV, the VFW, Team Red White & Blue, The Mission Continues — they built institutions that serve veterans at scale and will continue to do so long after the founders are gone. You don't have to build something that big. You can build a local chapter. You can found a small business that creates jobs and serves your community. You can establish a scholarship fund. You can help build a nonprofit that solves a specific problem in your specific community.

Institutions outlast individuals. If you want your impact to compound over time, build something with structure.

The Cultural Vector

Some veterans change the culture of the environments they inhabit. They raise the standard in their workplaces. They model a different kind of leadership in their civic organizations. They bring a level of accountability and integrity to their communities that shifts what people expect and accept. This is quieter than institution-building, but it is extraordinarily powerful over time.

Every environment you enter, you have the opportunity to raise the standard slightly. To model what leadership without ego looks like. To demonstrate that accountability and care are not opposites. To show that it's possible to operate with extreme discipline and extreme humanity simultaneously.

Do this consistently, and you change the cultures around you. That's a legacy that doesn't require a building with your name on it.

The Advocacy Vector

Some veterans find that their most important contribution is using their credibility and their platform to advocate for those who can't advocate for themselves — for veterans in the VA system, for communities being under-served by government, for policies that would change outcomes at scale. This is political in the broad sense — about power and who has it and how it gets used — and veterans who engage in advocacy bring a credibility and a moral authority that is difficult to manufacture.

If there is an injustice that you are uniquely positioned to see and to speak about, don't stay quiet because the arena feels messy. The arena is always messy. That's where the work happens.

Defining Your Personal Legacy

This isn't a graduation speech. We're not going to tell you to dream big and believe in yourself. What we're going to ask you to do is more specific than that:

Define, in concrete terms, what you are building. Not who you want to be seen as. What you are *actually building*, with your actual choices, your actual time, and your actual relationships.

Then ask yourself, honestly: are your daily actions accumulating toward that thing? Or are they accumulating toward something else — something comfortable, something reactive, something that other people wanted for you?

Legacy is not a destination. It's a direction. The question is whether you're moving in it.

The uniform is off. The mission is yours to define. Define it well, and live it hard, and the people coming behind you will have something real to inherit.

Practical Exercises

Exercise 1: The Influence Audit

Map your current civilian environment — workplace, community, social network. For each sphere, identify:

- Who do you have influence with, and why?
- Where do you have zero influence, and what would it take to build it?
- What specific relationships do you need to invest in over the next 90 days?
- Where are you trying to use authority you don't actually have yet?

Write it out honestly. The gap between where your influence actually is and where you need it to be is your leadership development target.

Deliverable: A one-page influence map with a 90-day investment plan.

Exercise 2: Civic Engagement Research Sprint

Spend 90 minutes this week researching your local civic landscape. Find:

- The names and meeting schedules of your city council and county commission
- Three advisory boards or commissions that have open seats or upcoming vacancies
- Two nonprofit organizations in your community whose mission aligns with your experience or values
- The next school board meeting date and whether board positions are up for election this cycle

Then identify one engagement target from that list and take one concrete first step: attend a meeting, email a staff contact, research the appointment process, or sign up to speak during public comment.

Deliverable: A one-page civic engagement map and a documented first step.

Exercise 3: Your Origin Story Draft

Write the first draft of your personal story framework using the three-movement structure from Lesson 4:

- **Movement 1:** The Mission (what you did — specifically)
- **Movement 2:** The Translation (what it built in you — specifically)
- **Movement 3:** The Application (how it shows up in what you're doing now)

Target: 300–500 words. Then read it out loud to yourself and time it. It should be approximately 90 seconds to 2 minutes. If it's longer, cut. If it's shorter, add specificity.

Deliverable: A written, timed personal story draft ready for practice and feedback.

Exercise 4: The Legacy Letter

Write a letter to yourself, dated ten years from now. In the letter, describe what you built over the past decade — specifically. What organizations exist because you helped create them? Who did you develop? What changed in your community because you showed up? What do the people who know you well say about you?

Don't write what you wish you had done. Write what you intend to do, but frame it in past tense as if it's already happened. This is not a fantasy exercise — it's a planning exercise that uses future projection to clarify present priorities.

Deliverable: A private letter to yourself, minimum 500 words, stored somewhere you'll find it in ten years.

Reflection Prompts

Use these for your personal journal, your peer discussion group, or your one-on-one sessions with a coach or mentor. Take them seriously — the reflection is where the real learning happens.

1. Think about the most effective leader you served under. What made them effective — and how much of it was rank versus something else? How much of that quality do you currently deploy in your civilian life?
2. Where in your current civilian environment are you operating from authority you don't actually have? How is that going? What would influence-based leadership look like in that same situation?

3. Is there a civic issue in your community that genuinely angers or concerns you? What would it look like to address that issue through civic engagement rather than complaint?
 4. Think about a specific junior service member you led or influenced. Where are they now? What did you give them that they're still using? What do you wish you had given them that you didn't?
 5. What is the most honest version of your personal story — including the parts you typically leave out? Why do you leave them out? What would happen if you included them?
 6. When you imagine your legacy, what do you picture? Is that picture driven by what you actually value, or by what you think you're supposed to want?
-

Discussion Prompts

Use these in your group sessions, cohort discussions, or online community forum.

1. **On civilian leadership:** What is the hardest part of transitioning from authority-based to influence-based leadership? Share a specific situation where you either navigated that transition well or got it wrong — and what you learned.
 2. **On civic engagement:** What has kept you from getting more involved in your community's civic life? Is it time? Cynicism about whether it matters? Not knowing how to start? What would have to change for you to take one real step in the next 30 days?
 3. **On mentorship:** Think about the person who most helped you during your transition — or the person you wish had been there to help you. What specifically did they do (or what would you have needed)? How does that shape how you approach mentoring others?
 4. **On legacy:** What does "service after service" mean to you personally? How are you currently living that out — or how are you not living it out? What's honest about that?
-

Quiz Questions

Question 1: What is the fundamental difference between authority-based and influence-based leadership?

- A) Authority-based leadership is more ethical
- B) Authority-based leadership works because of institutional position; influence-based leadership works because of trust and relationship
- C) Influence-based leadership is faster in high-stakes situations
- D) Authority-based leadership only works in the military

Answer: B — Authority-based leadership operates through institutional structure and position; influence-based leadership is built on personal credibility, trust, and demonstrated value. Both are legitimate; civilians environments primarily require the latter.

Question 2: According to the lesson, what is the most common failure mode for veterans trying to lead in civilian environments?

- A) Being too quiet and not asserting themselves
- B) Lacking technical skills
- C) Moving too fast without building relational capital and listening first
- D) Not having enough leadership experience

Answer: C — Veterans' bias for action, which serves them well in operational environments, can undermine civilian leadership when applied before relationships are built and context is understood.

Question 3: Which of the following is NOT listed as an effective entry point for civic engagement?

- A) Advisory boards and commissions
- B) Nonprofit board service
- C) Waiting to be recruited by a political party
- D) School board service

Answer: C — The lesson emphasizes that civic engagement requires personal initiative; no one will knock on your door. The other options are all identified as legitimate, accessible entry points.

Question 4: When mentoring a younger veteran, which of the following is identified as the most effective approach?

- A) Sharing your own success story so they have a model to follow
- B) Asking more than you tell, and helping them clarify their own thinking
- C) Making yourself available for crisis support at any hour
- D) Creating a formal accountability structure with weekly assignments

Answer: B — Good mentorship helps someone think through their own situation rather than handing them your conclusions. Asking powerful questions is more effective than giving continuous advice.

Question 5: What does the lesson identify as the three-movement structure for building a personal story?

- A) Background, Skills, Goals
- B) Service, Sacrifice, Success
- C) The Mission, The Translation, The Application
- D) Who You Were, Who You Are, Who You Want to Be

Answer: C — The Mission (what you did), The Translation (what it built in you), and The Application (how it shows up now) create a framework that is specific, honest, and audience-relevant.

Question 6: According to the lesson, what is a TEDx talk most accessible to?

- A) Only academics and professionals with published research
- B) Celebrities and well-known public figures
- C) Anyone with a compelling, specific story and genuine insight, including veterans
- D) Only people with existing public speaking experience

Answer: C — TEDx events are locally organized and actively seek speakers with compelling stories and real insights. A veteran with a well-developed, honest story is an excellent candidate.

Question 7: According to Lesson 5, what is the most accurate definition of "legacy"?

- A) What people say about you at your funeral
- B) The awards and recognition you accumulate during your career
- C) What continues after you stop actively pushing it — institutions, people, and cultures you've shaped
- D) The single most important thing you accomplish in your lifetime

Answer: C — Legacy is defined as what continues and compounds after you stop actively driving it — people you've developed, institutions you've helped build, cultures you've shaped.

Question 8: Which "vector of legacy" is described as the most durable?

- A) The Institution Vector
- B) The Advocacy Vector

- C) The People Vector
- D) The Cultural Vector

Answer: C — The People Vector — investing in, developing, and mentoring individuals who then carry that impact forward — is identified as the most durable form of legacy because it is self-replicating.

Question 9: What does the lesson mean when it says civic engagement requires showing up "consistently"?

- A) Showing up only when issues directly affect you
- B) Regular, sustained presence over time — attending meetings, building relationships, doing the unglamorous work — which is the foundation of civic influence
- C) Running for office immediately after getting out
- D) Posting frequently on social media about civic issues

Answer: B — Civic influence is built through sustained, consistent presence and participation over time — not one dramatic action, not online commentary, but showing up repeatedly for the work.

Question 10: According to Lesson 3, what does "peer mentorship" mean and why does it matter?

- A) Mentoring people who are slightly junior to you in rank
- B) Finding one senior mentor who covers all areas of development
- C) Relationships with veterans at a similar transition stage, sharing resources and hard-won lessons without a power differential
- D) Participating in formal VA-sponsored mentorship programs

Answer: C — Peer mentorship is relationships with veterans at a similar stage — same context, same challenges, no power differential — which often provides more immediately applicable support than formal mentoring.

Module Assignment

Leadership Philosophy Statement + Civic Engagement Commitment

This assignment has two deliverables. Both are serious. Both require honest reflection rather than performative answers.

Part 1: Your Leadership Philosophy Statement

Write a 400–600 word leadership philosophy statement. This is not a LinkedIn bio. This is not a resume bullet. This is a personal document — something you could hand to someone you're responsible for leading and say, "This is how I operate and why."

Your statement should address:

- What you fundamentally believe about people — their potential, their reliability, their motivations
- How you make decisions, especially under uncertainty or pressure
- What you owe the people you lead
- What you expect from the people you lead
- How you handle failure — your own and others'
- What leadership, at its core, means to you after everything you've experienced

Be honest. The clichés are easy to write and worth nothing. The honest, specific version — even if it's rougher and less polished — is the one that will actually guide your behavior.

Part 2: Civic Engagement Commitment

Identify one specific civic involvement opportunity and write a 200–300 word commitment statement that addresses:

- What the opportunity is (specific organization, board, campaign, or initiative)
- Why this particular opportunity aligns with your skills, experience, and values
- What your first concrete step will be (not "research it" — a specific action with a specific date)
- What you're willing to commit to over the next six months

You will be held accountable to this commitment in Module 12's integration discussion. Write something you intend to keep.

Submission: Both parts submitted together as a single document through the course platform.

Downloadable Worksheet: Module 10 Leadership and Legacy Toolkit

Download the full PDF from the course resources section. The worksheet contains four tools designed to be used together and revisited over time.

Tool 1: Leadership Style Inventory

Rate yourself honestly on each of the following dimensions, from 1 (significant growth area) to 5 (genuine strength):

Influence Building

- Building trust before being tested: ____
- Listening before directing: ____
- Investing in relationships without immediate return: ____
- Reading informal power structures in new environments: ____
- Adapting communication style to the audience: ____

Decision and Accountability

- Making clear decisions under uncertainty: ____
- Owning outcomes — good and bad — without deflection: ____
- Holding others accountable without making it personal: ____
- Receiving critical feedback without becoming defensive: ____
- Acknowledging when you were wrong and adjusting: ____

People Development

- Identifying and developing potential in others: ____
- Delegating effectively rather than over-controlling: ____
- Giving honest, useful feedback: ____
- Investing in people's growth beyond what's operationally required: ____
- Building successors rather than dependencies: ____

Self-Awareness

- Understanding how you're perceived by others: ____
- Recognizing when your leadership approach is creating friction: ____
- Managing your emotional state under pressure: ____
- Knowing what your leadership style costs the people around you: ____
- Seeking feedback on your blind spots: ____

Your three highest scores (genuine strengths to deploy):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Your three lowest scores (growth targets for the next 90 days):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

One specific action for each growth target:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Tool 2: Civic Engagement Map

Your Community Landscape

City/Town: _____

County: _____

Congressional District: _____

Local Government Structures

- City Council members (list names): _____
- Next city council meeting date: _____
- Active advisory boards/commissions: _____
- Boards with current or upcoming vacancies: _____

School District

- School board meeting schedule: _____
- Next election cycle for board seats: _____
- Current board positions and incumbents: _____

Nonprofit Organizations

Organization 1: _____

Mission alignment with my background: _____

Board meeting schedule / volunteer opportunities: _____

Organization 2: _____

Mission alignment with my background: _____

Board meeting schedule / volunteer opportunities: _____

Emergency Management

- Local CERT program contact: _____
- Emergency management office: _____
- Volunteer opportunities: _____

My Civic Engagement Target (for the next 6 months):

First Concrete Step (specific action + specific date):

Tool 3: Mentorship Tracker

My Mentees

Mentee 1:

- Name: _____
- Current challenge or focus: _____
- Meeting frequency and format: _____
- Last meeting date and what was discussed: _____
- Agreed next step (theirs): _____
- Agreed next step (mine): _____
- Next meeting date: _____

Mentee 2:

- Name: _____
- Current challenge or focus: _____
- Meeting frequency and format: _____
- Last meeting date and what was discussed: _____
- Agreed next step (theirs): _____
- Agreed next step (mine): _____
- Next meeting date: _____

My Mentors

Mentor 1:

- Name: _____
- Domain they mentor me in: _____
- Meeting frequency: _____
- Current focus of our work together: _____

- What I committed to do before next meeting: _____
- Next meeting date: _____

Mentor 2:

- Name: _____
- Domain they mentor me in: _____
- Meeting frequency: _____
- Current focus of our work together: _____
- What I committed to do before next meeting: _____
- Next meeting date: _____

Peer Network

Names of 3–5 peers at similar transition stage who I'm in regular contact with:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Next peer check-in scheduled: _____

Tool 4: Legacy Vision Worksheet

The People Vector

Who are the three to five people I am most intentionally investing in right now?

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

What specifically am I doing to develop them?

Who do I need to reach back and connect with from my past — junior service members, colleagues, community members — who could benefit from my current capacity?

The Institution Vector

Is there an organization I am helping to build, or that I want to help build?

What is my specific role in building or sustaining it?

What would I need to do to move from participant to builder?

The Cultural Vector

What standards am I raising in my current environment?

What behavior am I modeling that I want to see become normal around me?

Where am I currently tolerating a standard I don't actually believe in?

The Advocacy Vector

Is there an injustice, a policy gap, or a community need that I am uniquely positioned to speak about?

What would it look like to use my credibility and platform to advocate for that?

My Legacy Statement (draft)

In 150 words or fewer, describe what you intend to have built by the time you're done. Not who you want to be — what you intend to have built: in people, institutions, culture, and advocacy.

Review this quarterly. Update it as your clarity grows.

Module 10 Complete | Proceed to Module 11: Designing Your Next Mission

MISSION REBUILD™

Built for those who served. Designed for what comes next.

